

Name: Bella Illingworth

Job Title: Technical Support Specialist

Company: Base44

How I know her: She is my roommate and friend. She graduated from the University of Iowa in May 2026 with a BAIS degree, so I wanted to interview her because she recently went through the same program I am currently in and has already transitioned into a full-time career related to BAIS.

Questions I Asked:

- 1) How did you end up getting your position at Base44, and what do you think helped you stand out when you were applying?
- 2) What does a typical day or week look like for you in your role?
- 3) What skills from the BAIS program do you use the most in your job?
- 4) Was there anything you learned in BAIS that you did not think would be important at the time, but ended up being useful once you started working?
- 5) What is something you wish the BAIS program had prepared you for better before you entered the workforce?
- 6) Since Base44 is an AI-focused company, how has working there changed the way you think about careers in analytics, information systems, or software?
- 7) What is the biggest adjustment going from being a college student to working full-time in the industry?
- 8) If you were in my position right now as a BAIS student, what would you focus on before graduating to make yourself more competitive for jobs?

Interview Reflection:

For this assignment, I interviewed my roommate and friend, who graduated from the University of Iowa in May 2026 with a BAIS degree and now works full-time at Base44. I chose to interview her because she recently went through the same program I am currently in, so I thought her experience would be especially relevant to me. One of the biggest things I learned from our conversation was how important it is to take advantage of opportunities while still in college. She originally found Base44 through the Spring 2026 career fair when the company had an internship position available. She was able to turn that internship into a full-time position after graduation. She said that her previous experience developing a mobile app helped her stand out because she already had experience with Android,

Google, app submissions, and getting an app to work. This made me realize that having projects or experiences you can talk about during an interview can make a big difference.

Another thing I learned was that BAIS can lead to a much wider range of careers than I originally thought. Her current role is more focused on Information Systems and the technical side of BAIS instead of traditional business analytics. She said that topics such as cloud computing and information systems have been especially useful in her job. Before talking to her, I mainly thought of BAIS careers as positions involving data analysis, SQL, Python, and working with datasets. Her experience showed me that the degree can also lead into areas such as software, mobile development, cloud computing, and AI. She also explained that technology changes very quickly, so graduating with a degree does not mean that you are done learning. Staying open to learning new tools and technologies is going to be important throughout a career in this field.

Something that surprised me was how important communication and other professional skills have been in her job. She explained that presentations, group projects, and communicating with people might sometimes feel like assignments that just need to be completed while you are in college, but those skills become much more important once you begin working professionally. She also talked about learning how to receive constructive criticism and use it to improve instead of taking it personally. I think this was helpful because it reminded me that being successful in a technical career is not only about knowing how to code or analyze data. Being able to communicate, ask questions, work with other people, and continue learning are also important skills.

Her advice about technical skills and class projects was probably the most useful part of the interview for me personally. She said that if someone wants to work in a traditional analyst position, they should focus on skills such as Python, SQL, data cleaning, data processing, analyzing information, and explaining their results. For someone interested in a more technical Information Systems career, she recommended taking technical classes such as cloud computing seriously. She also said that she wishes she had spent more time fully understanding some of the material in her technical classes instead of only focusing on completing the class. That made me think differently about some of the classes I am taking now because the information may end up being more useful in a future job than it feels like now.

One piece of advice that especially stood out to me was to take class projects seriously and view them as potential portfolio pieces. She explained that students sometimes believe they have no experience because they have not completed an internship yet, but class projects can still demonstrate skills to employers. Instead of only completing a project for a grade, it is important to understand what you created, why you

created it, and what you learned from it so that you can explain it during an interview. Going forward, I want to pay more attention to projects that I could eventually include on my resume or use as examples of my skills.

Finally, she talked about the transition from college to working full-time. She said that adjusting to a consistent work routine was difficult at first, but she enjoys having more separation between work and her personal life. As a student, there is almost always another assignment, exam, or project to think about, even when you are technically done with school for the day. With a full-time job, she feels like she can finish her work and then spend her free time on hobbies or other things without constantly worrying about another assignment. She also emphasized not giving up during the job search. During her senior year, there were times when she was worried she would not find a job after graduation, but she continued applying, improving, and putting herself out there until an opportunity worked out. Overall, this interview made me feel more aware of the different paths available with a BAIS degree and showed me that both technical skills and professional skills will be important as I prepare for internships and eventually a full-time career.